

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Water outage

UTILITIES / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Check the utility notice to learn whether water service is interrupted and whether an advisory applies. Use stored or commercially bottled water for drinking and essential care. Service returning does not automatically mean tap water is safe.

Do now.

**Find the notice**

01

Check the affected address, restoration estimate and any advisory.

**Prioritize safe water**

02

Reserve approved water for drinking, medications, formula, food and pets.

**Plan hygiene**

03

Use local health instructions for sanitation and safe handwashing without running water.

**Wait for clearance**

04

Follow flushing and treatment instructions once the utility restores service.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Inventory clean containers and safe water, then prioritise drinking, food, medicines and hand hygiene. Do not use nonpotable water in food or formula. Plan toilet and waste arrangements separately and keep them away from food and water storage.

Watch for.

Do not use heating-system or radiator water for drinking.

People & practical needs.

Give one person responsibility for clean drinking-water containers and another for dirty water or sanitation. Keep containers manageable for the person who must lift them; avoid unmarked bottles accessible to young children.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Build an emergency water supply and know how your household will handle sanitation.

Check the next usable option

Build an emergency water supply and know how your household will handle sanitation.

When the first option is unavailable

Inventory clean containers and safe water, then prioritise drinking, food, medicines and hand hygiene. Do not use nonpotable water in food or formula. Plan toilet and waste arrangements separately and keep them away from food and water storage.

Questions in the field.

Can stored water serve every task?

Separate drinking and food-preparation water from water for cleaning or flushing. Keep clean containers covered and labeled. A source suitable for a toilet is not necessarily safe for hands, utensils or drinking.

What changes when pressure returns?

Find the utility's actual notice. Returning flow does not by itself establish drinking safety after a pressure loss. Use the relevant boil-water, do-not-drink or do-not-use guide and check whether the notice has been lifted.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Water outage · official guidance

<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/about/index.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/water-outage/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.